



Argentina's matches. It began with Lionel Messi escaping a booking in the title holder's opening fixture against Algeria after stepping on an opposition player's calf. Then the list kept growing.

Its Round of 16 clash against Egypt created quite an uproar across the footballing world, with the sport's governing body and its chief being openly accused of favouring the title holder and its "poster boy". The African side led by two goals for 78 minutes before Argentina staged a comeback. Egypt argued the turnaround was aided by the referee's decision to deny it a penalty, disallow a goal and make several other contentious calls. Emotions ran high after the match, with Egypt's second goalscorer, Mostafa Ziko, saying, "It's clear that this tournament has been fixed."

Egypt, however, was not the only side subjected to contentious refereeing. Norway's dream run

began to unravel against England when Jude Bellingham equalised to make it 1-1. Moments earlier, however, the ball had seemingly struck the Spidercam wire before falling kindly for Anthony Gordon to provide the assist.

The Snickometer, an old acquaintance of cricket fans, showed no spike when the ball appeared to hit the Spidercam wire. Yet it somehow detected Croatian Igor Matanovic's hair to disallow a goal that would have taken the 2018 finalist's Round of 32 clash against Portugal to penalties.

Perhaps the most blatant abuse of power came when host U.S.'s forward Folarin Balogun's red card against Bosnia-Herzegovina in the first round of the knockouts was suspended for a year for seemingly no reason.

A few days later, Trump revealed he had called FIFA president Infantino and asked for the decision

**Flashpoint:** United States striker Folarin Balogun, 25, was dismissed for serious foul play against Bosnia-Herzegovina and should have received an automatic suspension. AP

to be reviewed.

"That wasn't even an infraction. That was two guys running at full speed that happened to crash into each other," the 80-year-old said, despite replays showing Balogun's foot making forceful contact with Tarik Muharemovic's ankle.

Honourable mentions also go to the hydration breaks and the 624 minutes of advertisements fans around the world had to endure. Then there was, of course, the 27-minute half-time show in the final, which drew widespread criticism.

As the world shifts its focus to 2030, one can only hope FIFA learns from what transpired and retains authority over the biggest spectacle in world sport.